

Interface pictures

Want to check out what the interfaces of these players look like? We've put them up for you on www.thinkdigit.com/d/playerinterface



Toshiba's Libretto W100

Toshiba is releasing a limited edition dual screen concept PC called Libretto W100 to commemorate its twenty-five innings in the notebook sector

DVD player test



Onida HDR-5522 Atom

tinctively different. All three players from Soyer were below Rs. 2000, which is considerably cheaper than any of the other players including the sole offering from Moserbaer - MBI K666AMU. Speaking of Moserbaer the video performance and user interface was dismal. The colours were washed out and when dealing with fast motion, you could see horizontal lines forming every now and then. Which is to say that the performance was exactly at par with the Soyers mentioned earlier.

A surprising performer however was the Soyer 338MC. It had an improved remote, a slightly more visually appealing UI and great performance for a player depending on component output. We found the colours rendered by this player to be vivid. Our yardstick for this was the initial part of our test scene from the movie *Crash* - very few players were able to reproduce the reflections on the car window and the motion, but this one did a decent job of it. Looks wise the player was nothing to write home about but a nice little discovery was the covered USB port. A thoughtful feature for most households here where dust is a constant menace. We looked at video quality from USB too. Apart from the Philips players,

this little guy was next best at upscaling those standard 700MB movie files. The price to performance ratio was good enough for it to emerge as our best buy for this test.

The Philips players were priced rather high and scored considerably higher on performance parameters. The Philips DVP 3588 not only looked stunning with its brushed metal body, it exhibited exceptional video performance too. The front of the player



Philips DVP3588

was crafted in such a way that the LCD display lit up from behind a brushed metal finish translucent panel.

This way the information displayed on the eight-segment style LCD looked like it was etched on the body itself and when it was off it looked showed off a singular finish. It was one of two DVD players to have an HDMI out. The other one being the Onida Atom. The Philips DVP 3588 clearly was the better performer. Speaking of Onida players the pricing and quality difference between the two players was unusual. The one with HDMI out was priced only Rs. 100 above the one without the HDMI out

(DFX-5979) while the performance divide was much greater - over 15 per cent. Who'd buy the DFX-5979? We would certainly not recommend it.

The Atom on the other hand is a decent looking player with good DVD performance for Rs. 3,590. It's got a piano black finish, touch sensitive buttons and a curvy form factor. The only place it falls short compared to the Philips players was USB playback which was below par.

Features

Features really helped players stand out from each other especially in the lower range where performance was pretty much the same - equally good or equally bad - whichever way you looked at it. Players this time around, upped the ante to include a host of features such as CD ripping, copying from disk, greater file sup-

port and hindi language support. We also considered the User Interface as part of the

feature comparison because after all if you're actually going to use the enhancements such as picture slideshows, or music playback, the interface needs to be user friendly. The Philips players were distinctly ahead of the rest in terms of features. For instance, their on screen display showed a lot of detail such as bit rate of the file being played, the time left for movie,

for chapter etc. However we'd have liked a progress bar but somehow no DVD player was able to incorporate it. Many of the lower end players came with memory card support, Philips players however lost points for not including the same on their offerings. The UI of most players looked like it came from the same mould. For browsing content on flash drives the players recurred every item be it songs, movies or pictures into a single folder making finding a particular item a total nightmare. On the other hand the Philips players and surprisingly the Soyer 338MC had a combination of tree/folder structure browsing and browsing by item type.

The DVP 3568 was the budget offering from Philips. It had great upscaling on DivX video and all the features of its elder sibling such as media copy, CD ripping, and hindi interface. The only things where it fell a little short were the HDMI out and .wmv support. For a component based player the pure DVD playback quality was excellent. If you like the like the aesthetic appeal of this Philips player and the usability of a great UI we'd recommend it as a good buy for a price of Rs. 4,299.

Our best buy again was a surprising performer in the features department. Without mincing words we can safely say that the Soyer 338MC is a cheap player. And yet it comes with nice features such as CD rip-



Soyer 3388MC

